MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



OPERATIONS

THE RECOVERY GAP: WHY FIXING THE FAILURE IS NOT RESTORING TRUST

Six chapters on fairness, complaint closure, the recovery paradox, recurrence and responsible recovery.

60 independent studies in a meta-analysis of satisfaction with service complaint handling.

ORSINGHER, VALENTINI AND DE ANGELIS 2010, NOT A RECOVERY RATE

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EDITORIAL · VOLUME 9

After the fix, whose problem is it?

A service can be repaired on paper while its failure continues to live in the customer's day.

Consider the difference between two sentences: the issue has been closed, and the person affected has recovered. The first usually describes an internal decision. The second asks whether a customer received a usable remedy, an honest explanation and a credible next commitment. They are not interchangeable. A completed task, a corrected order and a polite apology may all be necessary; none automatically settles the human consequence of a broken promise. This ninth volume follows a failure through three operating worlds: a room problem that crosses hotel shifts, a last-mile delivery that arrives incomplete, and a wholesale commitment that has to survive a transfer from sales to fulfilment. These are documented categories of the author's work, not verified accounts of one particular guest, driver or reseller; the scenes that give them shape are constructed and labelled. The research is demanding. It connects complaint handling to perceived fairness and satisfaction, but does not promise that successful recovery automatically creates loyalty. A customer may appreciate the response and still decide not to return. Conversely, an issue recorded as unresolved may be under active, responsible management. Honest recovery needs both an operational account and the customer's perspective. Our question is not whether employees are nice or whether the complaint screen is green. It is whether an organisation can close the gap between correcting its own work and restoring enough reliability for the customer to make the next decision.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

HOW EVERY CHAPTER IS BUILT

1 **The living scene**
A shift, a ramp, a desk at 03:00: one piece of work followed as it actually happens, with the hand-off where it breaks. Scenes are constructed from real categories of work and say so.

2 **The conceptual and scientific breakdown**
The mechanism behind the scene, named with the model that explains it, and the research that tests it: the study, its population, its year and its limits, before it is applied anywhere else.

3 **The operating protocol for action**
What a working team can try on Monday: fields, questions, a cadence and a count, each with an owner, a next step and a return of information to the people who do the work.

THE READING CONTRACT

Field
Real categories of operational work, no invented personal incidents.

Evidence
Population, design, outcome and limits travel with every finding.

Action
A case is closed to a justified state, never to the most flattering label.

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RESEARCH NOTE

The evidence is not a promise

Service recovery research examines different outcomes in different populations. A conclusion must travel with its limits.

Tax, Brown and Chandrashekaran (1998) examined how complaining customers evaluated outcomes, procedures and interpersonal treatment. Homburg and Fürst (2005) studied organisations and their complaining customers together, distinguishing clear complaint-management rules from a supportive internal environment. These are useful frameworks; neither offers a universal amount of compensation, a universal response time or proof of success for a particular hotel. Orsingher, Valentini and de Angelis (2010) combined 60 independent studies of satisfaction with complaint handling. De Matos and colleagues (2007) found a positive average service-recovery-paradox effect on satisfaction, but no significant average effect on repurchase intention, word of mouth or corporate image. Das and colleagues (2026) synthesised 147 studies involving 82,901 people in 24 countries, all on online service failures: relevant for reasoning about justice and attribution, silent about hotels, loading ramps or wholesale partners.

60
studies: complaint-handling satisfaction meta-analysis, 2010

147
studies: online failure and recovery synthesis, 2026

3
outcomes: remedy, experience and future relationship

The constructs differ. A person can be satisfied with how a complaint was handled and still withhold loyalty. The research counts are published sample descriptors, not performance results, and none of them measures the author's workplaces.

OUR READING

The population, design and outcome are part of every finding, not optional fine print.

Sources: Chiara Orsingher, Sara Valentini & Matteo de Angelis, Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science 38(2), 2010; Celso Augusto de Matos, Jorge Luiz Henrique & Carlos Alberto Vargas Rossi, Journal of Service Research 10(1), 2007; Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998; Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005; Manish Das, Charles Jebarajakirthy, Haroon Iqbal Maseeh, Weng Marc Lim & Jinal Sameer Shah, Journal of Business Research 202, 2026

Orsingher, Valentini and de Angelis (2010); de Matos, Henrique and Rossi (2007); Tax, Brown and Chandrashekaran (1998); Homburg and Fürst (2005); Das et al. (2026).

CHAPTER I · THE PROMISE THAT FAILED

The room that remained a problem

A reported defect can be entered correctly and still remain the guest's burden.

CONSTRUCTED HOTEL SCENE, NOT A DOCUMENTED GUEST INCIDENT

A guest reports a problem with a room in the evening. The receptionist listens, records the issue and passes it to the responsible team. Later, the night shift sees that an action was taken. The internal note is concise and the case may appear administratively complete. But the guest has not received a clear update. The next morning, the guest must decide whether to explain the story again or let it go. Nothing in this scene proves a system error, an unhelpful employee or a failed repair. Each stage may have been completed within its local task description. The story illustrates a subtler defect: no one has identified the whole experience as a single piece of work. A repair is a technical result. Closure, from the guest's perspective, also requires knowing what was done and what to expect if the symptom returns.

The author has documented work with room-maintenance concerns, housekeeping issues, Night Audit reporting and handovers. The room, guest, sequence and outcome above are imaginary; no name, property or private workflow is reconstructed. The management problem is the interval between reporting a defect, making a correction and informing the person who must live with the result.

OUR READING

The final owner of a problem may not be the person who reported it, logged it or repaired it.

Sources: Christopher W. L. Hart, James L. Heskett & W. Earl Sasser Jr., Harvard Business Review 68(4), 1990; Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Constructed composite from documented categories of hotel work; the service-recovery literature behind it is Hart, Heskett and Sasser (1990) and Tax et al. (1998). The essay named below keeps a complaint open after the guest walks away.

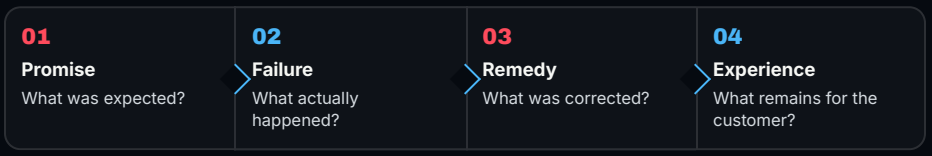
More in the essay The angry guest at 2 a.m.

CHAPTER I · THE PROMISE THAT FAILED

Service failure has two clocks

One clock measures internal work. The other measures the customer's exposure to a problem.

A useful recovery analysis begins by identifying the original promise. Was the product complete? Was the room usable? Was the delivery reliable at the agreed point? The next question is the customer consequence: time lost, uncertainty, inconvenience, repeated contact or a decision postponed. Internal teams record the events they can control. Customers experience the chain of events they must endure. A room defect can require a specialist action, but the customer should not become the informal coordinator between departments. A missing item may be found quickly in the warehouse while the recipient still waits for a remedy. A reseller may accept an apology about an order, but its own commitments to customers remain exposed. Different sectors, different authority and risks; the common problem is a gap between local task completion and an end-to-end promise.



Hart, Heskett and Sasser's early argument stressed identifying mistakes and responding to them: managerial guidance, not a controlled estimate of what response time creates loyalty. The sharper question is what a customer would regard as a usable outcome, and who has authority to confirm it. Proof of being informed must not be confused with proof of being satisfied, and a positive reaction does not certify the technical repair.

OUR READING

An internal completion timestamp and a customer-impact duration answer different questions.

Sources: Christopher W. L. Hart, James L. Heskett & W. Earl Sasser Jr., Harvard Business Review 68(4), 1990; Mary Jo Bitner, Bernard H. Booms & Mary Stanfield Tetreault, Journal of Marketing 54(1), 1990; Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Framework interpretation informed by Hart, Heskett and Sasser (1990), Bitner, Booms and Tetreault (1990) and Tax et al. (1998). The four stages are an editorial model.

CHAPTER I · THE PROMISE THAT FAILED

Two clocks on one invented case

A fully synthetic timeline shows how far the internal clock can run ahead of the customer's.

SYNTHETIC EXAMPLE, AUTHORED FOR THIS VOLUME; NOT EMPLOYER DATA

HOURS AFTER THE REPORT, ONE INVENTED CASE



Every value is invented so the two clocks can be compared, not measured at any property or station. On the internal clock the case is finished after three hours. On the customer's clock the problem is still open until the remedy is verified, more than a day later; in between, the customer does not know whether anything happened. The gap is not an accusation against the technician, the receptionist or the night shift: each acted inside a task. It is the interval nobody owned. A real operation has its own durations and its own authorised ways to confirm a remedy; the question the chart asks is which clock the dashboard reports.

OUR READING

Report the customer's clock beside the internal one, or the gap between them stays invisible.

Source: Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Every value on this page is synthetic, authored for this volume; the two-clock reading follows the previous page. The author's PDF describes the two clocks without drawing them.

CHAPTER I · THE PROMISE THAT FAILED

Capture the loss, not only the ticket

A complaint should be recorded so the next person can act without restarting the customer's story.

1. **Name the original promise**
   The customer-visible outcome the organisation had undertaken to provide.
2. **Separate report from verification**
   The customer statement, the observed facts and what is still uncertain.
3. **Describe remaining customer impact**
   The unresolved consequence, without collecting more private data than required.
4. **Assign an authorised owner**
   The role able to decide or escalate the remedy, not simply the team receiving an email.
5. **Commit to the next update**
   A realistic communication point and the permitted channel.
6. **Confirm the disposition**
   What was corrected, what was communicated and what remains unresolved.

An editorial documentation checklist, not a replacement for a hotel complaint SOP, a delivery claim policy or a commercial approval rule; urgent safety or legal matters follow their authorised escalation routes at once. A trial can compare a small anonymous sample of records before and after revising the handover: could the receiving worker act with the information available, how often did the customer repeat the same facts, and did the promised update occur?

OUR READING

A complete complaint record is one that enables the next responsible action, not merely one with every field filled.

Sources: Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998; Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005

Original operating protocol, inspired by Tax et al. (1998) and Homburg and Fürst (2005); not a validated intervention or a hotel-certified SOP.

CHAPTER II · THREE DIMENSIONS OF FAIRNESS

The apology that could not deliver

A correct answer can still feel unfair when the customer carries all the inconvenience.

CONSTRUCTED WHOLESALE SCENE, NOT A CLAIMED SALES INCIDENT

An independent reseller has been told that a shipment can follow a confirmed order. The delivery date changes. The account representative calls promptly and explains what the supplier can now offer. A replacement date is agreed, yet the reseller faces a separate cost: explaining the change to its own buyers and reorganising plans it cannot easily move. The supplier may believe the problem is fixed as soon as the new date is recorded. The reseller evaluates more than the date. Was the replacement outcome reasonable? Was the process understandable and free of repeated effort? Did the representative treat the reseller's position with respect? The same remedy is experienced differently if communication is evasive, if the customer had to chase several departments or if the explanation arrives only after a missed promise.

The author previously worked across sales, stock and warehouse coordination with a network of 61 active wholesale resellers. That background is documented; the conversation, delay and outcome here are invented. A partner is not an employee of the supplier, and a supplier cannot assume the partner will silently absorb a change.

OUR READING

Fairness is not merely what the company gives back. It also concerns how the customer had to obtain it.

Source: Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Constructed wholesale illustration; justice framework after Tax, Brown and Chandrashekaran (1998). The essay named below is about those 61 resellers and trust.

More in the essay 61 resellers: what wholesale taught me about trust

CHAPTER II · THREE DIMENSIONS OF FAIRNESS

Three questions behind one complaint

Customers can judge the result, the path to the result and the way they were treated.

Justice theory supplies a more precise language than a generic instruction to make the customer happy. Distributive justice concerns the perceived fairness of the outcome: the replacement, correction, reimbursement or other authorised remedy. Procedural justice concerns access, timeliness, consistency, effort and transparency in the process. Interactional justice concerns dignity, honesty and the quality of interpersonal communication. The dimensions can disagree. An excellent remedy delivered only after repeated calls leaves the procedure judged poorly. A considerate apology cannot substitute for a missing item. A technically correct refusal still demands a respectful explanation and a route for review. Conversely, kindness cannot authorise a frontline worker to grant an unsafe or prohibited exception: fairness operates inside the real authority of the service.

01
Outcome
What did the customer actually receive?

02
Procedure
How much uncertainty, delay and effort remained?

03
Treatment
Was the person treated honestly and respectfully?

Tax, Brown and Chandrashekaran (1998) found that complaining customers evaluated complaint incidents along outcomes, procedures and interpersonal treatment. Their findings prescribe no universal ranking of the three dimensions: failure type, industry and outcome change the relative weight of what the customer receives, how the process unfolds and how the interaction is conducted.

OUR READING

A recovery decision should be checked against all three forms of fairness, within authorised limits.

Source: Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Tax, Brown and Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998. Applications to wholesale, last-mile and hotels are editorial comparisons.

CHAPTER II · THREE DIMENSIONS OF FAIRNESS

Which kind of fairness matters?

Two evidence syntheses show why the answer depends on the outcome being studied.

60 independent studies in the meta-analysis of satisfaction with complaint handling: a literature count, not a recovery-success percentage

Orsingher, Valentini and de Angelis (2010) combined 60 independent studies of satisfaction with complaint handling. For that outcome, their meta-analysis reported the strongest relationship for distributive justice, followed by interactional justice, with a weaker association for procedural justice. But satisfaction with complaint handling did not mediate the justice dimensions' effects on overall satisfaction and return intention, as conventional wisdom might suggest. Gelbrich and Roschk (2011) examined a broader model: organisational responses, customer justice perceptions, post-complaint satisfaction and behavioural intentions. They found support for an intervening role of perceived justice and satisfaction and cautioned against treating compensation as the only relevant part of recovery: employee behaviour and procedures belong to the structure. The two reviews differ in samples, modelling choices and dependent variables. A customer rating the immediate remedy is not answering the same question as a customer deciding whether to buy again next month, and neither outcome measures the original technical fault.

OUR READING

The studies assess relationships among measured perceptions and outcomes; they do not make a single remedy universally optimal.

Sources: Chiara Orsingher, Sara Valentini & Matteo de Angelis, Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science 38(2), 2010; Katja Gelbrich & Holger Roschk, Journal of Service Research 14(1), 2011

Orsingher, Valentini and de Angelis (2010), Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science 38, 169–186; Gelbrich and Roschk (2011), Journal of Service Research 14, 24–43. Published syntheses, not measurements of the author's workplaces.

CHAPTER II · THREE DIMENSIONS OF FAIRNESS

The fairness check before closure

Before declaring a complaint resolved, inspect the customer experience from three angles, within the service's real boundaries.

01	**Outcome**	What promised result or authorised alternative has actually been delivered? What remains unverified?
02	**Procedure**	How many times did the customer need to explain, ask or wait? Was the next step and decision authority clear?
03	**Treatment**	Did the communication acknowledge the problem, explain facts without speculation and preserve the customer's dignity?
04	**Boundaries**	Are safety, privacy, legal requirements and compensation authority respected?
05	**Evidence**	What source confirms the action? What is known about the customer's response, if any?

The check needs no lengthy survey after every interaction. A sample of anonymised records can reveal recurring gaps: corrections without updates, responses without ownership, apologies without a remedy. Do not infer satisfaction from silence: a customer may not complain again because they are satisfied, because they gave up or because they switched provider. Standardisation prevents arbitrary treatment; discretion lets different situations receive different permitted responses; neither replaces transparent review.

OUR READING

Ask what was fair about the outcome, the process and the treatment. Record evidence, not a declaration of happiness.

Sources: Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998; Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005; Chiara Orsingher, Sara Valentini & Matteo de Angelis, Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science 38(2), 2010

Original editorial checklist informed by Tax et al. (1998), Homburg and Fürst (2005) and Orsingher et al. (2010).

CHAPTER III · CLOSED IS NOT RESOLVED

The case marked complete

A system status can be accurate inside one department while incomplete for the recipient.

CONSTRUCTED LAST-MILE EXAMPLE, NOT A VERIFIED DELIVERY CASE

A delivered order is reported as incomplete. An operational colleague opens a case, checks what the system recorded and asks a receiving team to investigate. A missing item is located. The internal case is marked as corrected. At that exact moment, the physical item has not necessarily reached the original recipient, and the recipient does not necessarily know when it will. The process has advanced; the customer outcome remains uncertain. Nothing in this story says that a particular scanner malfunctioned, that a driver was wrongly blamed or that a customer received the wrong amount. The danger is a quiet inflation of a label. Staff may mean that the internal investigation is complete. A dashboard may display the same word as if the customer problem were finished. An auditor may later read it as proof of success. The fix is not to distrust every status; it is to define what the status proves, what it does not prove, and which additional outcome needs confirmation.

The author's confirmed operating categories include incomplete orders, missing bags, mixed trolleys, loading exceptions and KPI reviews. The specific sequence above is deliberately invented.

OUR READING

A case status is evidence about a workflow stage, not automatic evidence of the customer's outcome.

Constructed example from documented last-mile categories; the closure distinction is an editorial framework, not a claim about an employer's system labels. The essay named below reads a scan as a witness, not a judge.

More in the essay The scanner is a witness, not a judge

CHAPTER III · CLOSED IS NOT RESOLVED

Three records, three different truths

Do not force a single green flag to stand for correction, communication and relationship recovery.

The internal ledger should say what happened to the work: investigated, corrected, awaiting external action or formally rejected. A communication ledger should say what the affected person has been told, without pretending that delivery of a message proves acceptance. A customer-outcome ledger should distinguish the reported impact from what has actually been remedied. These are not three bureaucracies; they are three meanings that should be visible in one responsibly designed record. A hotel technician can complete an authorised repair while the next shift still owes an update. A warehouse can prepare a replacement while transport remains pending. A sales team can accept a revised promise while the partner still needs to adjust its own commitments. In every case the first fix is local; the customer consequence crosses the organisational boundary.

01

Work state

What operational step has been completed?

02

Update state

What was communicated, and when?

03

Customer state

What remedy or residual impact is known?

Operational systems should use exact state definitions and timestamps; the more handovers, the greater the temptation to collapse progress into one word. Homburg and Fürst (2005) distinguish formal guidelines from an organisational climate that supports complaint handling. Their result is no argument against structure: structure should make responsibility clearer, and employees should have the support to carry it through.

OUR READING

One record can show all three dimensions without calling any one of them total closure.

Sources: Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005; James G. Maxham III & Richard G. Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 2002; Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Interpretation based on Homburg and Fürst (2005), Maxham and Netemeyer (2002) and Tax et al. (1998). The three-ledger framework is editorial.

CHAPTER III · CLOSED IS NOT RESOLVED

Forty cases marked closed

A fully synthetic cohort shows what one green label can hide when three records collapse into one.

SYNTHETIC EXAMPLE, AUTHORED FOR THIS VOLUME; NOT EMPLOYER DATA

INVENTED COHORT OF 40 CASES, ALL SHOWN AS CLOSED



Every count is invented so the arithmetic can be followed. The dashboard shows forty closures; the work ledger supports thirty-six. Twenty-eight customers were told something and nineteen confirmed receipt. Fourteen remedies are verified, and only six records say what inconvenience remained. None of this proves the other cases went badly: some customers decline contact, some remedies cannot be verified. It shows which claim each number supports, and that “closed” carried five meanings at once.

OUR READING

Count closures by what they prove. A single total hides the ledger that is weakest.

Source: Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005

Every value on this page is synthetic, authored for this volume; the three ledgers follow the previous page. The author's PDF describes the inflation of the label without counting it.

CHAPTER III · CLOSED IS NOT RESOLVED

Perceptions change over time

Measuring a complaint immediately after a reply is not the same as understanding the relationship after recovery.

Maxham and Netemeyer (2002) conducted two field studies of customers' perceptions of complaint handling over time. One followed customers who had complained to a bank for the first time, with questionnaires after the failure, after the recovery and about two weeks later; the other surveyed customers of a home-construction firm after a first product failure and recovery attempt. Their model related perceptions of fairness to satisfaction with recovery, overall firm satisfaction and future intentions. Satisfaction with recovery was a stronger predictor of positive word-of-mouth intention than overall firm satisfaction, whereas overall firm satisfaction was a stronger predictor of purchase intention. The customer can respond favourably to one recovery effort while holding a separate view about continuing the relationship; a prediction of intention is not a verified future purchase.



Timing matters for operations too. Immediate feedback captures the experience of receiving an answer. A later check, where appropriate and permitted, can ask whether the remedy held or the problem returned. Neither is a mandate to contact every customer repeatedly: consent, local policy and communication fatigue set real constraints.

OUR READING

Satisfaction with complaint handling and future purchase intention are distinct outcomes and may change at different times.

Source: James G. Maxham III & Richard G. Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 2002

Maxham and Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 239–252 (2002), two field studies. No longitudinal measurement is claimed for the author's workplaces.

CHAPTER III · CLOSED IS NOT RESOLVED

Design a two-stage closeout

Close the local task when it is finished. Close the customer-impact question only when its status is known.

1. **Confirm the technical disposition**
   The action completed and its evidence, or the case marked as still pending.
2. **Record the receiving owner**
   The role responsible for the next customer-visible step.
3. **Separate notification from consent**
   An authorised update sent is not approval or satisfaction.
4. **Verify outcome proportionately**
   The promised remedy, checked with an appropriate evidence source and privacy safeguards.
5. **Describe the residual impact**
   If full restoration is impossible, what remains and the approved next response.
6. **Retain the learning signal**
   The underlying category and recurrence marker, linked to improvement without exposing identities.

A pilot can compare anonymised case records with the language in use today: count unsupported closure claims, missing handover information and promised updates that did not occur, with the denominator defined first. Unknown customer responses stay unknown. Do not keep cases open indefinitely: each task needs a stable completion definition, with remaining customer impact shown separately and assigned to a responsible next step.

OUR READING

It is legitimate to close a task and still say that the customer outcome has not yet been verified.

Sources: James G. Maxham III & Richard G. Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 2002; Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998; Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005

Original two-stage closeout model, informed by Maxham and Netemeyer (2002), Tax et al. (1998) and Homburg and Fürst (2005).

CHAPTER IV · THE RECOVERY PARADOX

The customer who did not return

A grateful response to a remedy does not guarantee a decision to use the service again.

CONSTRUCTED CUSTOMER SCENE, NOT AN OBSERVED RETENTION OUTCOME

A delivery arrives late. The provider responds rapidly, accepts its part of the problem and makes an authorised correction. The customer thanks the service team for handling it well. Internally, the incident becomes an example of excellent recovery. Weeks later, in the invented scene, the customer chooses another provider for a future order. The recovery interaction went well; the next purchase did not follow. The opposite story is also possible: a person may have a poor service experience, accept an adequate remedy and remain a customer. Neither narrative, by itself, proves a paradox. The service-recovery paradox is a more specific research claim: in some circumstances, a customer who experiences a failure followed by a strong recovery may report greater satisfaction than one who had no failure. Evidence about that comparison has been inconsistent across studies.

This scene is not based on a documented customer record from the author's work. It shows why managers should not infer loyalty from a thank-you, infer satisfaction from the absence of a complaint, or celebrate a failure as an opportunity to impress. The responsible objective is to prevent avoidable failure and respond well when it occurs.

OUR READING

Recovery should not be designed as a marketing opportunity to create failures. Prevention remains the better promise.

Source: Celso Augusto de Matos, Jorge Luiz Henrique & Carlos Alberto Vargas Rossi, Journal of Service Research 10(1), 2007

Constructed illustration informed by de Matos, Henrique and Rossi (2007); no retention, review or loyalty outcome is attributed to the author. The essay named below asks whether one case is a bad day or a problem.

More in the essay A bad day or a problem?

CHAPTER IV · THE RECOVERY PARADOX

Satisfaction is not loyalty

Managers often join distinct psychological and behavioural outcomes into a single word: recovered.

After a complaint, several questions may have different answers. Was the person satisfied with the immediate handling? Are they satisfied with the company overall? Do they intend to buy again? Do they actually return? Would they recommend the company? These are not interchangeable dependent variables, and the recovery paradox depends on which outcome is compared with which baseline. A thoughtful apology may lower anger even when the physical consequence cannot be removed. A fair replacement may settle a transaction without rebuilding confidence in delivery reliability. A durable correction may reduce future risk without generating positive word of mouth. None of this makes the recovery useless; it means the organisation must describe the result it actually achieved.

01	**Complaint satisfaction**	How did the person evaluate the handling of this specific issue?
02	**Firm satisfaction**	How does the person view the provider overall?
03	**Return intention**	Does the person say they might use the service again?
04	**Actual behaviour**	Is there later observable activity, measured ethically and with valid attribution?

There is also a selection problem in ordinary reports. People who complain are a visible subset of those affected; unreported failures never enter the recovery queue, and retained customers do not reveal why they stayed. Without defined denominators and a comparison, a percentage of satisfied complainants cannot tell us the recovery effect on the whole customer base.

OUR READING

Reporting should name the specific outcome rather than hide all outcomes under the word recovery.

Sources: Celso Augusto de Matos, Jorge Luiz Henrique & Carlos Alberto Vargas Rossi, Journal of Service Research 10(1), 2007; James G. Maxham III & Richard G. Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 2002

Definitions and research interpretation after de Matos et al. (2007) and Maxham and Netemeyer (2002). Loyalty is a longer-horizon outcome, not a sticker granted at case closure.

CHAPTER IV · THE RECOVERY PARADOX

A paradox with limits

The often-repeated claim that a complaint can create greater loyalty needs a serious qualification.

De Matos, Henrique and Rossi (2007) performed a meta-analysis of the service-recovery paradox, an effect with mixed results in individual studies. Their cumulative mean effect was positive and statistically significant for satisfaction. It was not statistically significant, on average, for repurchase intention, word of mouth or corporate image. Research design, type of respondent and service category influenced the satisfaction effect. These findings do not imply that every successful recovery lifts satisfaction above a no-failure baseline, nor that the true effect on future behaviour is exactly zero: a nonsignificant average is evidence of uncertainty about a general effect, not proof that no context can ever show one. A memorable apology cannot be assumed to erase operational risk or restore a commercial relationship.

FOUR OUTCOMES IN THE 2007 META-ANALYSIS

01	**Satisfaction**	Positive average effect.
02	**Repurchase intention**	No statistically significant average effect reported.
03	**Word of mouth**	No statistically significant average effect reported.
04	**Corporate image**	No statistically significant average effect reported.

Hart, Heskett and Sasser (1990) made a managerial case for recovering from inevitable service mistakes. That article is useful as guidance and should not be treated as the meta-analytic evidence itself: compelling management cases and generalisable empirical estimates are different things.

OUR READING

Evidence for a satisfaction paradox is not evidence for a universal loyalty paradox.

Sources: Celso Augusto de Matos, Jorge Luiz Henrique & Carlos Alberto Vargas Rossi, Journal of Service Research 10(1), 2007; Christopher W. L. Hart, James L. Heskett & W. Earl Sasser Jr., Harvard Business Review 68(4), 1990

De Matos, Henrique and Rossi (2007), Journal of Service Research 10(1), 60–77; Hart, Heskett and Sasser (1990). The significance labels are qualitative summaries from the paper, not invented effect sizes.

CHAPTER IV · THE RECOVERY PARADOX

Measure what recovery really changed

A practical evaluation separates incident quality, response quality and later relationship outcomes.

1. **State the comparison**
   Like customer groups or incidents, not only cases that received positive feedback.
2. **Record recovery effort**
   What was actually repaired, communicated and verified?
3. **Define immediate outcomes**
   A clearly worded customer measure where permitted; missing answers are never filled in as positive.
4. **Define longer-term outcomes**
   Expressed intention separated from later observed behaviour, with privacy safeguards.
5. **Document contextual differences**
   Complaint type, severity, business line and recurrence, before generalising.
6. **Avoid rewarding failures**
   Recognise response quality without creating incentives to tolerate preventable defects.

Begin with descriptive measures and clear limits; without a defensible comparison, avoid causal claims, since customer mix, seasonality and other operating changes may explain changes in later purchases. Review the rate and severity of original failures alongside recovery quality: better satisfaction with apologies does not prove the original service has become more reliable.

OUR READING

An excellent recovery is an obligation after failure, not a substitute for a reliable service.

Sources: Celso Augusto de Matos, Jorge Luiz Henrique & Carlos Alberto Vargas Rossi, Journal of Service Research 10(1), 2007; James G. Maxham III & Richard G. Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 2002; Katja Gelbrich & Holger Roschk, Journal of Service Research 14(1), 2011

Original evaluation protocol guided by de Matos et al. (2007), Maxham and Netemeyer (2002) and Gelbrich and Roschk (2011).

CHAPTER V · WHEN THE SAME FAILURE RETURNS

The second broken promise

A customer evaluates the recurrence as new evidence about what to expect next time.

CONSTRUCTED REPEATED-FAILURE SCENE, NOT A VERIFIED CUSTOMER CASE

A business customer receives an incomplete order. The supplier responds professionally and arranges a correction. The problem appears to be over. On a later delivery, a different item is missing. The customer now asks a different question. Instead of asking only how the latest mistake will be fixed, the customer wants to know why the process can be trusted to work next time. The repeated event changes the meaning of the first event. A single failure could have seemed temporary. The second may suggest a stable weakness, even if the causes are unrelated. It is the organisation's job to investigate what actually happened, not to dismiss that perception or to accept an unverified common cause. Fair treatment needs evidence about recurrence, not convenient storytelling.

The scenario is invented to explain a mechanism studied by attribution researchers. It is not an account of a real partner among the 61 resellers in the author's previous wholesale network, nor evidence of two linked incidents at an actual company. An article about trust loses its own credibility if it invents the very failures it claims to understand.

OUR READING

A repeat complaint is not only another case. It is a challenge to the credibility of the previous remedy.

Source: Yves Van Vaerenbergh, Chiara Orsingher, Iris Vermeir & Bart Larivière, Journal of Service Research 17(4), 2014

Constructed example informed by Van Vaerenbergh et al. (2014); no actual repeated failure, customer or order is attributed to the author. The essay named below traces a recurring damage figure to its causes.

More in the essay How we worked with damage

CHAPTER V · WHEN THE SAME FAILURE RETURNS

The customer's theory of the cause

People do not only notice a failure. They infer whether it could have been prevented and whether it will happen again.

Attribution theory makes two distinctions useful for operations. Perceived controllability asks whether the organisation could reasonably have prevented the event. Perceived stability asks whether the underlying cause is likely to persist. These are customer interpretations, not direct root-cause measurements; an investigation can support, qualify or contradict them, but cannot erase them by stating that the case has been closed. Van Vaerenbergh, Orsingher, Vermeir and Larivière (2014) meta-analysed the links between service-failure attributions and customer outcomes. Controllability attributions elicited stronger negative emotions than stability attributions, while stability was related to both transaction-specific and overall satisfaction; the connections to loyalty and negative word of mouth ran through emotional and satisfaction pathways. The findings give no formula for predicting any named guest or delivery customer.

01

Controllable?

Could the provider reasonably have prevented it?

02

Stable?

Is the cause expected to persist or recur?

03

Supported?

What evidence supports the proposed explanation?

Communication must therefore be accurate and proportionate. If the cause is unknown, saying so with an honest next step is more defensible than claiming that the problem can never recur. If the same defect is found repeatedly, compensating each transaction without changing the process leaves the central question unanswered: what will make the next promise more reliable?

OUR READING

Do not confuse the customer's attribution with a verified root cause. Investigate both.

Source: Yves Van Vaerenbergh, Chiara Orsingher, Iris Vermeir & Bart Larivière, Journal of Service Research 17(4), 2014

Van Vaerenbergh et al. (2014), Journal of Service Research 17(4), 381–398. The cross-sector examples are editorial.

CHAPTER V · WHEN THE SAME FAILURE RETURNS

The chain from response to trust

A remedy influences perceptions through a sequence, not through a magical direct jump to loyalty.

147 studies of online service failure and recovery, with 82,901 participants across 24 countries, in Das et al. (2026): a research sample, not a field success rate

Gelbrich and Roschk (2011) synthesised complaint-handling evidence along a path from organisational responses to fairness judgements, then to post-complaint satisfaction and behavioural intentions. The organisational inputs included compensation, favourable employee behaviour and procedures. The model supported mediation by fairness and satisfaction without making every element equally important for every outcome. A large corrective action may fail to restore trust if the customer sees the procedure as evasive or the explanation as unreliable; a transparent explanation without a usable remedy may be well received yet operationally insufficient. Das and colleagues (2026) integrated attribution and justice perspectives across 147 studies of online service failure and recovery. Its size makes it informative about the online literature; it does not license transferring the same effect sizes to physical wholesale, parcel delivery or hotel operations.

01	02	03	04
Response	**Justice**	**Experience**	**Future**
Action, procedure, conduct.	Perceived fairness.	Satisfaction and emotion.	Intentions and behaviour.

OUR READING

The mechanism can guide hypotheses in other sectors; its published effect sizes must stay in their studied context.

Sources: Katja Gelbrich & Holger Roschk, Journal of Service Research 14(1), 2011; Manish Das, Charles Jebarajakirthy, Haroon Iqbal Maseeh, Weng Marc Lim & Jinal Sameer Shah, Journal of Business Research 202, 2026

Gelbrich and Roschk (2011), Journal of Service Research; Das et al. (2026), Journal of Business Research 202, article 115752. The pathway is conceptual.

CHAPTER V · WHEN THE SAME FAILURE RETURNS

From apology to prevention evidence

A repeated issue requires a loop that returns from the customer consequence to the operating process.

1. **Group comparable incidents**
   A consistent classification, with personal information protected.
2. **Verify the actual mechanism**
   Observable process conditions; the reported cause is not treated as proved.
3. **Distinguish one-off from recurring**
   Frequency and exposure, including cases nobody formally complained about.
4. **Assign correction authority**
   Who can improve the upstream process, and who controls immediate recovery.
5. **Test one bounded change**
   The original failure outcome and any adverse effect on speed or cost.
6. **Return a truthful update**
   What is verified and permitted to disclose, without claiming certainty too early.

The process-improvement owner and the customer-communication owner may be different people, but the organisation must connect their work: if the customer hears that the cause was fixed, the evidence should support that message. A changed procedure without monitoring is a hypothesis; a monitoring result without a transparent case definition is an unreliable claim. The most credible message may be that the cause is still under investigation, an interim safeguard is in place and another update is scheduled.

OUR READING

Trust grows from a history of kept commitments. An apology is not a replacement for that history.

Sources: Yves Van Vaerenbergh, Chiara Orsingher, Iris Vermeir & Bart Larivière, Journal of Service Research 17(4), 2014; Katja Gelbrich & Holger Roschk, Journal of Service Research 14(1), 2011

Original recurrence-response protocol, informed by Van Vaerenbergh et al. (2014) and Gelbrich and Roschk (2011). No internal systems, incident files or other customers' data are to be disclosed.

CHAPTER VI · DESIGNING THE RECOVERY SYSTEM

The handover that keeps a promise

A recovery can fail between two competent people if neither owns the complete customer commitment.

CONSTRUCTED CROSS-DEPARTMENT SCENE, NOT A NAMED INCIDENT

A frontline colleague receives a complaint and explains the next step. A specialist team receives a technically correct task and completes its portion. A separate colleague assumes the customer must have been informed by someone else. No one is acting maliciously. The handover is missing one field: who is responsible for completing the promise made to the person affected. The scenario deliberately combines generic service features; it is not a documented hotel handover, driver escalation or wholesale complaint. It exposes a design problem: organisations often optimise the handoff of work while neglecting the handoff of responsibility for the customer outcome. Repair, communication and learning then occupy different systems or meetings.

A recovery system cannot eliminate every error, guarantee that every person is satisfied or give all frontline workers unlimited authority. It can make the next decision explicit. Each case should have a verifiable state, an authorised owner, a communication commitment and a disposition that says what remains unknown. The first accountable action is to stop a problem from disappearing into the gap between teams.

OUR READING

The customer does not care which department made the promise. The organisation must know who owns its completion.

Sources: Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005; Christopher W. L. Hart, James L. Heskett & W. Earl Sasser Jr., Harvard Business Review 68(4), 1990; Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Constructed organisational scene; management design informed by Homburg and Fürst (2005), Hart et al. (1990) and Tax et al. (1998). The essay named below follows a mistake between departments.

More in the essay Mistakes get lost between departments

CHAPTER VI · DESIGNING THE RECOVERY SYSTEM

Rules and culture must work together

A complaint system needs both repeatable definitions and people supported to use them.

Homburg and Fürst (2005) distinguished a mechanistic approach to complaint handling, built around explicit procedures and guidelines, from an organic approach, built around a supportive internal environment. Their dyadic study of organisations and their customers linked both to customers' perceptions, with primarily complementary effects, and found differences between business-to-consumer and business-to-business settings and between services and manufacturing: a warning against one recovery script for every environment. A procedure can specify how to record the failure, assign an owner and confirm an update. But employees must be able to ask for help, describe an unrealistic standard and escalate matters they cannot authorise; otherwise a beautifully documented process produces a stack of complete records and a line of customers still waiting. The reverse also holds: goodwill without clear authority and state definitions becomes heroic improvisation that collapses at the next shift change.

01
Standard
Define state, ownership and exceptions.

02
Support
Make decisions and help accessible.

03
Learning
Return verified causes to the process.

The operational decision is not procedure versus empathy but how to make them mutually reinforcing: a complaint process fair, auditable and short enough to use when work is busy, while allowing a responsible response to the particular consequence a customer faces. Sensitive compensation, legal and safety matters require the employer's policies, not an editorial formula.

OUR READING

Consistency without judgement becomes bureaucracy. Judgement without a dependable process becomes chance.

Source: Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005

Homburg and Fürst (2005), Journal of Marketing 69(3), 95–114. The complementary approach and context effects are from the published abstract; the operating model is editorial.

CHAPTER VI · DESIGNING THE RECOVERY SYSTEM

Six gates to honest closure

A practical system distinguishes each decision and names the next owner before a case can disappear.

1. **Receive**
   The customer-visible failure and the exact original promise.
2. **Verify**
   Report, verified facts, technical status and unknowns, kept apart.
3. **Own**
   An authorised decision maker and the next feasible action.
4. **Remedy**
   Complete or escalate the approved correction; record evidence of delivery.
5. **Inform**
   A clear, respectful update; sent, received and accepted kept distinct.
6. **Learn**
   Recurrence classified, the upstream mechanism checked, the prevention action reviewed.

A pilot can start with a few de-identified cases: where does a case move backward because the next owner lacks information, and how long passes between report, verified action and customer update? The gates are no mandatory queue: a safety concern may need action before a full record exists, and legal deadlines and employer rules take precedence. The purpose is to preserve responsibility and evidence, not to delay the remedy.

OUR READING

Close the record honestly, not optimistically. A pending outcome must remain visible until the agreed next decision.

Sources: Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998; Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005

Original editorial protocol after Tax et al. (1998) and Homburg and Fürst (2005), with the learning gate after Van Vaerenbergh et al. (2014); not a certified SOP or tested treatment.

FIELD TOOL

The Recovery Closure Card

One problem, one responsible owner, one clear customer commitment. Use only anonymised examples in public; a blank means not verified, never automatically positive.

01	**Promise and impact**	what was promised, and what customer-visible consequence remains?
02	**Evidence**	what is directly verified? what is only reported or assumed?
03	**Authority and owner**	who can decide the remedy, and who owns the customer update?
04	**Remedy and timing**	what was actually done, and when is the next permitted commitment?
05	**Customer-facing closure**	what was communicated? was delivery confirmed, or is the response unknown?
06	**Recurrence and learning**	was the underlying cause checked and assigned for prevention?

Sources: Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998; Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005

Use only with approved processes; route urgent cases under the applicable safety or legal procedure. In an internal test, check whether the next colleague can act, the agreed update occurs and prevention remains owned. Never publish identifiable case information.

Open the tool: Last-Mile CX Control Tower stivencatalyst.com/tools/cx-control-tower/

CLOSING ESSAY

The promise after the apology

A company repairs the part it controls. The customer remembers the whole experience.

An apology is a human beginning, not an operational conclusion. It can recognise inconvenience, reduce defensiveness and make a difficult conversation possible. The next question is what the organisation can actually restore. A room must be usable. An order must be complete or its remedy honestly agreed. A trading partner needs a reliable update before it can make promises of its own. These are different services, but each ends where the customer receives something they can use. The temptation is to count the visible acts of recovery: tickets, response times, credits, replacements and closure rates. The numbers are useful only when we know what each one proves. A message sent is not a message understood. A technician finished is not necessarily a guest reassured. A replacement prepared is not a parcel delivered. A satisfied complainant is not automatically a loyal customer. An organisation can be fast at repairing its own record and slow at lifting the burden from the person affected.

The evidence is neither cynical nor sentimental. Research on fairness shows that the outcome, the procedure and the treatment all contribute to the customer experience. Studies of the recovery paradox warn that a good response may improve satisfaction without restoring future buying intentions. Attribution research reminds us that people try to decide whether a failure was preventable and whether it will recur. The more predictable the underlying process becomes, the less work needs to be done by apologies. From the front desk to the loading ramp to the wholesale relationship, the responsible manager asks one more question after the internal case is closed: what consequence is the customer still carrying, and who knows? The answer may be that the remedy is complete. It may also be that the person declines contact, that the outcome cannot be verified or that some inconvenience cannot be undone. Honesty about those limits is stronger than pretending the system has removed them. A recovery system earns its place when it helps employees act fairly, makes unresolved work visible and improves the process that failed. It does not promise perfect satisfaction. It promises that the organisation will not mistake its own convenience for the customer's recovery.

OUR READING

Fix the failure. Explain the remedy. Verify the result where possible. Learn before the next promise.

Editorial conclusion. No failed recovery, lost customer or neglected complaint is attributed to any named employer.

METHOD

Evidence before the closure claim

An evidence-informed narrative synthesis, not an original field study. The author's documented categories are last-mile incomplete deliveries, operational coordination, wholesale partner relationships and hotel complaint handovers; every conversation and scene is labelled hypothetical, and every count describes published research.

01	**Frameworks**	Hart, Heskett and Sasser (1990) is a managerial article; Bitner, Booms and Tetreault (1990) classify 700 critical incidents; Tax et al. (1998) and Homburg and Fürst (2005) are empirical models, not universal remedies.
02	**Field studies**	Maxham and Netemeyer (2002): two field studies, a bank and a home-construction firm; intentions, not verified purchases.
03	**Meta-analyses**	De Matos et al. (2007); Orsingher et al. (2010), 60 studies; Gelbrich and Roschk (2011); Van Vaerenbergh et al. (2014); Das et al. (2026), 147 studies, 82,901 participants, 24 countries, online services only.
04	**Invented counts**	The two clocks (2, 3, 14, 26, 38 hours) and the forty closed cases (40, 36, 28, 19, 14, 6) are illustrations flagged on their pages; no proportion is a benchmark.

The Recovery Closure Card, the two-stage closeout and the six gates are editorial proposals, not validated assessments or employer-approved procedures. No guest, driver, reseller, payment or confidential employer information is reproduced. Editorial standard: a framework, a field study, a meta-analysis and a proposal are named as such, and the sentence stops claiming where the evidence stops.

Sources: Christopher W. L. Hart, James L. Heskett & W. Earl Sasser Jr., Harvard Business Review 68(4), 1990; Mary Jo Bitner, Bernard H. Booms & Mary Stanfield Tetreault, Journal of Marketing 54(1), 1990; Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998; James G. Maxham III & Richard G. Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 2002; Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005; Celso Augusto de Matos, Jorge Luiz Henrique & Carlos Alberto Vargas Rossi, Journal of Service Research 10(1), 2007; Chiara Orsingher, Sara Valentini & Matteo de Angelis, Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science 38(2), 2010; Katja Gelbrich & Holger Roschk, Journal of Service Research 14(1), 2011; Yves Van Vaerenbergh, Chiara Orsingher, Iris Vermeir & Bart Larivière, Journal of Service Research 17(4), 2014; Manish Das, Charles Jebarajakirthy, Haroon Iqbal Maseeh, Weng Marc Lim & Jinal Sameer Shah, Journal of Business Research 202, 2026

Every source is cited at its DOI or page on the next page; the ten records, their journals, volumes and years were checked against the publishers' metadata and abstracts.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Where the claims come from

The figures in this volume come from the sources below, each with its year. The scenes are constructed; the protocols are proposals; what is research is named as research.

The Profitable Art of Service Recovery
Christopher W. L. Hart, James L. Heskett & W. Earl Sasser Jr., Harvard Business Review 68(4), 1990

The Service Encounter: Diagnosing Favorable and Unfavorable Incidents
Mary Jo Bitner, Bernard H. Booms & Mary Stanfield Tetreault, Journal of Marketing 54(1), 1990

Customer Evaluations of Service Complaint Experiences: Implications for Relationship Marketing
Stephen S. Tax, Stephen W. Brown & Murali Chandrashekaran, Journal of Marketing 62(2), 1998

Modeling Customer Perceptions of Complaint Handling over Time: The Effects of Perceived Justice on Satisfaction and Intent
James G. Maxham III & Richard G. Netemeyer, Journal of Retailing 78(4), 2002

How Organizational Complaint Handling Drives Customer Loyalty: An Analysis of the Mechanistic and the Organic Approach
Christian Homburg & Andreas Fürst, Journal of Marketing 69(3), 2005

Service Recovery Paradox: A Meta-Analysis
Celso Augusto de Matos, Jorge Luiz Henrique & Carlos Alberto Vargas Rossi, Journal of Service Research 10(1), 2007

A Meta-Analysis of Satisfaction with Complaint Handling in Services
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A Meta-Analysis of Relationships Linking Service Failure Attributions to Customer Outcomes
Yves Van Vaerenbergh, Chiara Orsingher, Iris Vermeir & Bart Larivière, Journal of Service Research 17(4), 2014

Online Service Failure and Recovery: An Integrated Meta-Analytic Perspective of Attribution and Justice Theories
Manish Das, Charles Jebarajakirthy, Haroon Iqbal Maseeh, Weng Marc Lim & Jinal Sameer Shah, Journal of Business Research 202, 2026



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

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ALL VOLUMES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/operational-treatise.html

Operational Treatise · Volume 9 · October 2026 · Stiven Catalyst
Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html